

“svchost.exe” which usually runs in multiple instances and together hosts many services running on the system. Do note that the paths of viruses will differ from those of the original files.

Besides file name, also look at the file size and network bandwidth in Task Manager. If there's a virus which creates a swarm of files in hidden system directories (such as in 'System Volume Information' folder on each partition/volume) then it would be utilizing plenty of disk space. Or if it comes with a malware which transfers your personal files from your documents library to a remote server then it would be utilizing network bandwidth.

Windows Vista and all higher versions of Windows come equipped with a very capable software named “Resource Monitor”. Launch it and you'll find yet another way to keep an eye on the processes in your system.

Auto-vigilance with anti-virus

Though these are some basic countermeasures, they won't work for some viruses e.g. those which are not meant to slow down PCs but to destroy data. We recommend you get an anti-virus and keep it updated; an internet connection is necessary for updation purpose. Avast anti-virus is effective and is legally free for home use; it provides a lot of flexibility and control. If you have money to spend to ensure security for any sensitive files on your computers, we'd say get yourself a protection suite for they come with more than just anti-virus software. Yet another defense is not running the computer as an administrator. Though UAC on Windows Vista and above provide a good level of security, an accidental click on a 'yes' in a random pop-up might allow a malicious code to execute. If you're vigilant enough, you should be fine because a virus can't cause much havoc on your computer unless it gains administrative rights. If you don't have an updated anti-virus, a virus without administrative privileges still leaves a window of escape for you – you can create a new account on the computer, transfer your documents to it and use that account instead!

Viruses enter via either removable media or the internet. Remain vigilant enough and do not install just about any software because, say, it promises you a larger set of smilies in Google Talk. Most (if not all) such software come bundled with viruses. Stay away from cracked software; always download patches and updates from the official vendors. A good browser which offers more security is better. We recommend Google Chrome, Mozilla Firefox and Opera compared to Internet Explorer for two reasons: i) Chrome and Firefox are more updated to the new HTML5 standards and ii) they're not deeply